

that document to provide context. Some e-mail programs will do this for you automatically when choosing to “Reply” to a received e-mail.

Instead of sending e-mail that says:

yes

Say:

> Can you cope without it till
> you get back?

yes

The greater-than sign (>) is the most conventional way to quote someone else’s e-mail words, but your e-mail software may use a different convention. Not quoting someone from a previous e-mail can quickly cause confusion in a conversation of back-forth e-mail.

A simple rule of thumb is: Will the other person remember exactly what I am responding to? If you are uncertain, then always quote the recipient, when answering or commenting on something he/she had written on some earlier e-mail.

Summary

You may know what you are talking about, but your readers may not. Give them the proper context by:

- m Giving useful subject lines
- m Quoting the previous message

Understanding E-mail Formats

The underlying rules governing e-mail transmission are highly standardized, but there are a large number of different software programs that can be used to read e-mail. It’s quite possible that the message you send won’t look at all the same when displayed